

4. Since all open source productivity tools are handled by the open source community, developers can actually monitor the user response and tweak their applications to better meet user needs. This really benefits users.
5. Productivity software organises different features in an intuitive way without actually copying another developer's work. Some of the users are quite picky about specific features of the system. If they need to switch from one product to the other, they might get frustrated in case the second product does not organise its different features in the same way as the one they've become used to.
6. Different productivity tools also take care of the tricky tasks such as converting spreadsheets full of data into graphs and charts, which makes it really easy to perform different analysis tasks on large data sets. This also saves a lot of the manual effort required to analyse huge data sets.
7. One of the emerging trends in productivity software is collaborative software. This means that multiple people can work together on the same file and that too, at the same time. For different desktop applications, all files must be saved on a networked disk drive that is accessible to all the collaborators. In the case of Web services, different users save files to a database present on the Web. All the collaborators can work on the specific file from any of the computers connected to the Internet.

A few open source productivity tools and their features

Scribus: This is an open source desktop publishing program which is available free of cost. It is developed keeping in mind the user interface as displayed in case of Paint.NET and Inkscape.

Its features are listed below.

- It sports a different layout, and the design tools are at par with its commercial competitors.
- It uses a macro language called GIMP, which is available with a number of pre-packaged macros (e.g., a calendar generator).
- It can produce professional-quality CMYK PDFs. It also has a 'preflight check' function in order to make sure that what we see is really what we eventually get.

We can get the best results out of Scribus when we use it in conjunction with a text processing system; it is not really a word processor in its own right and is not suited yet to laying out long-form documents. Also, as in the case of Inkscape, its internal support for colour matching systems is missing. We can partly work around this limitation.

SeaMonkey 2.0.6: SeaMonkey bundles different applications like Web browsing, IRC chat, e-mail and an HTML editor, into a single application. It is quite similar to Firefox and Thunderbird but, unfortunately, it hasn't attracted much attention yet. SeaMonkey 2.0 is really worth



Figure 1: Plugin loading screen for Scribus (Image source: googleimages.com)

a look. Apart from the plugin-friendly browser and the email client, the most attractive part is the HTML editor, which is slightly more polished than KompoZer but is not available separately. It is not a substitute for any full-blown page design application like DreamWeaver, but it really works well for the basic HTML assembly and the clean-up. It can also examine the tag structure of the existing pages.

AbiWord 2.8.6: This is actually a simple word processing application. It has been developed to emulate the look and feel of Microsoft Word circa Office 97 through Microsoft Office 2003. AbiWord also emulates the vast majority of Word's functions. This is especially useful for a live-collaboration function, which lets us connect to some other AbiWord user present across a network and to work on the same set of documents in real-time.

However, users do need to be cautious about a few things.

- AbiWord can be tripped up by the documents created in other programs.
- Some of the formats are not properly preserved, and some features supported in Word don't always function as expected.
- When working with the files created outside AbiWord, we should use copies instead of originals.

Task Coach 1.1.3: Task Coach is an application that uses a simpler and checklist-oriented approach to help us stay on top of our workload. Different tasks that need to be done can be organised into different categories such as the assigned dates and progress percentages. They can also be time-tracked, so that we get an idea of how much time we are really spending on any given project.

Some of the advanced features of this tool are:

- Can create sub-tasks and add 'effort' annotations to a given task, but we don't need to know about how to use them to make use of Task Coach.
- We can also visualise our tasks as more than just a list. We can see them using a timeline, a calendar view and a hierarchical view (for the sub-tasks).
- These task lists can also be synced using iCalendar, or through a Funambol server if we use one of them.

Dia 0.97: Dia is actually an open source tool that helps in drawing flowcharts and diagrams. It is much like AbiWord for illustrations. However, AbiWord just gives us what we need to create a certain class of the design and does not really burden